

Technology & Production Costs

Confidential planning brief | Generated for Strategy Task Force review

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Source: Production Economics Consortium

Benchmark: 41 comparable projects

Scope: AA/AAA PC-console studios

Development Economics by Genre Category

Production cost inflation is now most visible in specialized engineering, content tooling, QA automation, and live operations staffing. The most expensive projects are not always those with the largest maps or highest visual fidelity. Systemic complexity, persistent state, multiplayer operations, moderation, mod validation, and emergent AI behavior can create cost burdens that are less visible in early pitch materials.

Reusable technology remains a major advantage, but reuse should be evaluated by system fit, not label similarity. A studio with strong movement physics may still face new risk when adding city streaming or social hubs. A studio with strong UI and data systems may still struggle with autonomous character simulation. Production planning should therefore separate art/content scale, gameplay system novelty, backend complexity, and QA observability.

Genre Category	Typical Budget Range	Cost Drivers	Hidden Risk
Racing / driving	£12M-£18M	Vehicle handling, licensed content, tracks, platform optimization	Market differentiation can be harder than build execution
Skateboarding / action sports	£9M-£16M	Animation blending, physics feel, UGC tools, replay systems	Content variety and creator moderation can grow late
Life / cozy simulation	£18M-£30M	Persistent state, AI schedules, mod validation, object interactions	Small instability issues can become reputation-defining
Open-world social sports	£16M-£24M	World streaming, traversal systems, social hubs, live events	Scope can blur unless the core fantasy is tightly governed
Strategy / management	£8M-£14M	Data simulation, UI, balancing, scenario generation	Lower visual spectacle can reduce mainstream visibility
Survival crafting	£15M-£26M	World systems, co-op networking, crafting depth, AI ecology	Competitive saturation raises content and polish bar

Production Cost Pressure Index



Operational Guidance

Studios should require proof gates that match the highest-risk system in the genre: long-session stability for simulation, network reliability for social worlds, feel and animation quality for movement games, balance integrity for strategy and management, and content cadence for survival crafting. A greenlight case is more credible when the milestone plan proves the central risk before full production spending accelerates.